

NSF 26-508: TechAccess: AI-Ready America

A national program to coordinate readiness and accelerate deployment

Program Solicitation

Document Information

Document History

- **Posted:** March 25, 2026

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U.S. National Science Foundation

Directorate for Technology, Innovation and Partnerships

Innovation and Technology Ecosystems

Directorate for STEM Education

Directorate for Computer and Information Science and Engineering



National Institute of Food and Agriculture



Department of Labor

Employment and Training Administration



U.S. Small Business Administration

Letter of Intent Due Date(s) (required) (due by 5 p.m. submitting organization's local time):

June 16, 2026

State/Territory Coordination Hubs: June 16, 2026 (round 1); December 15, 2026 (round 2); June 1, 2027 (round 3)

Full Proposal Deadline(s) (due by 5 p.m. submitting organization's local time):

July 16, 2026

State/Territory Coordination Hubs: July 16, 2026 (round 1); January 15, 2027 (round 2); July 1, 2027 (round 3)



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Important Information and Revision Notes

This solicitation includes several deviations from the NSF Proposal & Award Policies & Procedures Guide (PAPPG) to accommodate the structure and requirements of the TechAccess: AI-Ready America program.

1. This solicitation limits the number of proposals that may be submitted for the State/Territory Coordination Hub awards to one proposal per institution.
2. In addition to NSF's standard merit review criteria, this solicitation introduces additional review criteria tailored to the objectives of the TechAccess: AI-Ready America program.
3. Awards made under this solicitation will incorporate special award conditions, including a requirement for State/Territory Coordination Hubs to work with the National Coordination Lead, which will be selected through a separate Other Transaction instrument.
4. The TechAccess: AI-Ready America program consists of three distinct components — State/Territory Coordination Hubs, the National Coordination Lead, and Catalyst Award Competitions — that will operate through separate solicitations or funding calls.

Proposals must be prepared in accordance with the [NSF Proposal & Award Policies & Procedures Guide \(PAPPG\)](#). Use the version of the guide that is in effect on the proposal's due date.

Summary of Program Requirements

General Information

Program Title:

TechAccess: AI-Ready America

A national program to coordinate readiness and accelerate deployment

Synopsis of Program:

TechAccess: AI-Ready America is a national-scale initiative to accelerate Artificial Intelligence (AI) readiness and adoption across the U.S. by strengthening coordination, leveraging partnerships and resources, filling

gaps, and scaling what works — so local and state priorities can lead in shaping an AI-driven economy that benefits all Americans.

Unlike initiatives centered around K – 16 education, AI-Ready America additionally reaches businesses, public-serving organizations, and individuals, among others, expanding access to AI knowledge, tools, and resources. The program also emphasizes practical implementation through hands-on assistance and workforce up-skilling, including experiential learning such as internships, project-based work, and apprenticeships, to ensure stakeholders can effectively apply and innovate with AI.

The program supports:

1. State/Territory Coordination Hubs (Coordination Hubs) – one in every state, the District of Columbia (DC), or territory in the United States – connecting partners, strengthening planning and deployment, and rapidly scaling approaches;
2. A National Coordination Lead (National Lead) – facilitating collaboration and knowledge sharing among Coordination Hubs, coordinating priority economic sectors, and informing national AI strategies; and
3. AI-Ready Catalyst Award Competitions – a series of topic-driven competitions issued over the course of the program to pilot and scale innovative approaches that address critical national AI readiness needs.

This funding opportunity focuses on Coordination Hubs. The National Lead will be funded as an Other Transaction (OT) offered through an Other Transaction Agreement Solutions Offering. AI-Ready Catalyst Award Competitions will be announced through an NSF-approved mechanism, with proposals submitted according to the instructions provided at the time of announcement.

Expanding Participation in STEM, NSF Priorities, and Gold Standard Science

NSF prioritizes cutting-edge discovery science and engineering research, advancing technology and innovation, and creating opportunities for all Americans. NSF has established priorities set forth by Congress, the administration and the NSF director to promote [NSF's mission](#). Proposers should review the list of [NSF priorities](#) and are encouraged to align their proposals with them, where appropriate. NSF also expects the highest standards of scientific rigor, integrity and adherence to appropriate tenets of [Gold Standard Science](#) in proposals, as appropriate for the field of science and research modality.

Cognizant Program Officer(s):

Please note that the following information is current at the time of publishing. See program website for any updates to the points of contact.

- AI-Ready America Program Directors, email: ai-ready@nsf.gov

Applicable Catalog of Federal Domestic Assistance (CFDA) Number(s):

- 17.280 --- Employment and Training Administration
- 47.070 --- Computer and Information Science and Engineering
- 47.076 --- STEM Education
- 47.084 --- NSF Technology, Innovation and Partnerships
- 59.037 --- U.S. Small Business Administration

Award Information

Anticipated Type of Award: Standard Grant or Continuing Grant

Estimated Number of Awards: 56

State/Territory Coordination Hub Awards: Up to 56 awards; one for every state, the District of Columbia, or territory in the U.S. Coordination Hubs will be selected over three rounds: 10 Coordination Hubs in round one, 20 in round two, and the remainder in round three. Each Coordination Hub Award will receive support of \$1M/year for three years, with the possibility for one additional year of support if the Coordination Hub can demonstrate a compelling need as it phases out or transitions to other sources of funding. Each Coordination Hub award will be made as a Standard Grant or Continuing Grant.

Anticipated Funding Amount: \$168,000,000 to \$224,000,000

The program will additionally support a National Coordination Lead award announced through an Other Transaction Agreement Solutions Offering as well as AI-Ready Catalyst Awards, to be announced through Dear Colleague Letters or through the National Coordination Lead.

Estimated program budget, number of awards and average award size/duration are subject to the availability of funds.

Proposal Preparation and Submission Instructions**A. Proposal Preparation Instructions**

- **Letters of Intent:** Submission of Letters of Intent is required. Please see the full text of this solicitation for further information.
- **Preliminary Proposal Submission:** Not required
- **Full Proposals:**
 - For proposals submitted via Research.gov, [PAPPG](#) guidelines apply.
 - For proposals submitted via Grants.gov, [NSF Grants.gov Application Guide](#) guidelines apply.

B. Budgetary Information

- **Cost Sharing Requirements:**

Inclusion of voluntary committed cost sharing is prohibited.
- **Indirect Cost (F&A) Limitations:**

Not Applicable
- **Other Budgetary Limitations:**

Not Applicable

C. Due Dates

- **Letter of Intent Due Date(s) (required)** (due by 5 p.m. submitting organization's local time):

June 16, 2026

State/Territory Coordination Hubs: June 16, 2026 (round 1); December 15, 2026 (round 2); June 1, 2027 (round 3)
- **Full Proposal Deadline(s)** (due by 5 p.m. submitting organization's local time):

July 16, 2026

State/Territory Coordination Hubs: July 16, 2026 (round 1); January 15, 2027 (round 2); July 1, 2027 (round 3)

Proposal Review Information Criteria

Merit Review Criteria:

National Science Board approved criteria. Additional merit review criteria apply. Please see the full text of this solicitation for further information.

Award Administration Information

Award Conditions:

Additional award conditions apply. Please see the full text of this solicitation for further information.

Reporting Requirements:

Standard NSF reporting requirements apply.

I. Introduction

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is rapidly transforming the U.S. economy, industry, and workforce, creating both unprecedented opportunities and significant challenges. While AI adoption is accelerating in some sectors, many states and communities lack the infrastructure, coordination mechanisms, and education and workforce capacity needed to fully leverage these technologies. These gaps underscore the urgency of building a coordinated national framework for AI readiness.

AI-Ready America is grounded in coordination — linking nationally developed resources and technical expertise with state-level leadership and local implementation to create a cohesive, adaptable AI infrastructure.

The program aligns with Administration priorities around promoting AI literacy, integrating AI into education, and sustaining America's global AI leadership, as articulated in recent executive orders including *Advancing Artificial Intelligence Education for American Youth* and *Removing Barriers to American Leadership in Artificial Intelligence*. Importantly, this program also aims to advance *America's AI Action Plan* and *America's Talent Strategy* by promoting AI literacy from classrooms to communities, coordinating AI skills development programs, and facilitating partnerships among state and local governments and workforce system stakeholders to support industry-driven training programs. AI-Ready America will dismantle barriers that slow AI adoption, reinforcing America's position as the global leader in responsible, innovation-driven AI.

The Directorate for Technology, Innovation, and Partnerships will facilitate the AI-Ready America program in collaboration with the Directorates for STEM Education and for Computer and Information Science and Engineering. This program complements NSF's current AI investments by strengthening state-level planning and integrating efforts with national-scale initiatives within and beyond NSF. By leveraging existing networks and partnerships, AI-Ready America seeks to create a scalable model for national AI readiness that drives innovation and opportunity.

The U.S. Department of Labor (DOL) will advance the program's impact by connecting Coordination Hubs to the public workforce and education systems, including through networks like American Job Centers, training pathways like Registered Apprenticeships, and initiatives like DOL's AI Workforce Hub. The U.S. Department of Agriculture's National Institute of Food and Agriculture (USDA-NIFA) will extend the program's impact into its networks within agricultural and rural communities, as well as other sectors, by connecting Coordination Hubs to the land-grant university and Cooperative Extension system and to NIFA's investments in research, extension and education. The U.S. Small Business Administration will further the program's impact by connecting Coordination Hubs to dedicated capital and counseling support networks for small businesses to start, grow, and expand.

NSF recently supported a workshop to scope the needs for AI-readiness. The [workshop report](#) can be found on the program page for TechAccess: AI-Ready America, which will be updated with other key reports as relevant.

II. Program Description

The vision of the AI-Ready America program is to enable a future where every individual, community, and business thrives in an AI-driven economy. The program aims to expand access to AI knowledge, tools, training, and capacity building so all Americans can participate in and benefit from emerging AI opportunities.

Central to this vision is a strategic approach that focuses on three priorities: strengthening coordination around AI readiness at local, state, and national levels in collaboration with community colleges and universities; leveraging existing networks and resources to accelerate AI adoption; and identifying and addressing gaps that must be filled to advance AI readiness.

The program defines "AI-Ready" as the continuum of literacy, proficiency, and fluency — the ability to understand, apply, and create with AI. Further, it sees "AI-literacy" as starting with understanding "Why AI?" and "When AI?".

The program goals are to:

1. Enable all Americans to be AI-literate and AI-ready.
2. Empower businesses — especially small and emerging enterprises — to adopt AI to increase competitiveness, productivity, and growth.
3. Support local governments and organizations in harnessing the power of AI to improve public services and spur local innovation.
4. Strengthen workforce capacity to apply and innovate with AI across education, business and economic sectors, and public services.

The program is structured around three funding support mechanisms: (1) State/Territory Coordination Hubs, which accelerate statewide AI readiness; (2) a National Coordination Lead, which provides national strategy and alignment; and (3) AI-Ready Catalyst Awards competitions, which rapidly pilots innovative approaches for potential national scaling.

Program Area 1: State/Territory Coordination Hubs

Coordination Hubs will serve as the center of state/territory-wide coordination to accelerate AI readiness and deployment. Each Coordination Hub will act as a neutral convening entity that connects local partners across education, workforce, industry, and government stakeholders; leverages established networks, assets, and organizations within the state/territory; facilitates knowledge exchange; and enables rapid scaling of successful AI adoption efforts. The Coordination Hubs are expected to work with the National Lead, once the National Lead is established, to ensure state priorities inform national strategies, approaches, and scaling, and that the state/territory benefits from shared resources and tools, best practices and knowledge sharing. Successful implementation will require a lead organization with statewide convening power and operational capacity, supported by a strong team of partners.

Primary responsibilities include but are not limited to:

1. AI Learning and Resource Navigator

Maintain a publicly accessible and user-friendly inventory of state and territory AI-related resources, including training programs, physical infrastructure, and support services.

2. State/Territory AI Readiness Strategic Plan

In collaboration with key partners and stakeholders, develop a strategic plan to meet state/territory priorities around AI readiness as well as identify the Coordination Hub's role. Integrate data collection and evaluation to monitor progress, guide adjustments, and support evidence-based decision-making.

3. AI Deployment Support

Provide hands-on assistance for AI adoption — including advisory services, training, and technical setup, integration, customization, and deployment — to help local governments and organizations, small businesses, and others implement AI solutions effectively. Coordination Hubs should leverage existing resources and partnerships with organizations that deliver hands-on local implementation support (e.g., with Cooperative

Extension, American Job Centers, Small Business Development Centers, Veterans Business Outreach Centers) wherever possible and mobilize additional assistance where gaps exist. Coordination Hubs may also develop an AI Deployment Corps — a roster of credentialed practitioners — aligned with the nationally coordinated AI Deployment Network managed by the National Lead.

4. AI Readiness Training & Capacity Building

Coordinate education, workforce, and industry partners across the state's K – 16 and workforce systems to strengthen AI readiness. Rather than delivering training directly, serve as a backbone organization that enables increased access to existing programs and resources, accelerates scaling of successful efforts, and aligns pedagogy and credentialing. Coordination Hubs should draw on established national AI literacy guidance, such as DOL's AI Literacy Framework, and align their efforts with federal education and workforce programs supported under the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) and the Strengthening Career and Technical Education for the 21st Century Act (Perkins V). This alignment should include both formal and informal mechanisms for demonstrating proficiency — such as micro-credentials, digital badges, competency-based assessments, and other flexible recognition pathways. Coordination Hubs should expand access to experiential AI learning opportunities across industry and public-sector settings. These may include, for example, hands-on activities, project-based work, and other practice-based experiences such as Registration Apprenticeships, that help learners build and apply AI skills. Additionally, Coordination Hubs should work with the National Lead to, for example, leverage best practices from other states, integrate sector-specific training, and disseminate nationally recognized guidance and tools.

5. Coordination Within Priority Sectors

Identify and convene stakeholders in economic sectors critical to the state's economy (e.g., energy, agriculture, local manufacturing, healthcare delivery, and education). Facilitate collaboration among education, workforce, and industry partners to align AI adoption strategies, workforce training, and resource sharing within these sectors. If strong coordination already exists in a sector, Coordination Hub efforts should complement and leverage those efforts rather than duplicate them. Activities may include sector-specific convenings, development of shared implementation plans, AI skill frameworks for occupations in priority industries, and contributions to best-practice repositories managed by the National Lead.

Program Area 2: National Coordination Lead

The National Lead will partner with NSF and the AI-Ready America program partners, to provide a coherent national strategy and approach to readiness at the state, local, and national levels. This includes supporting Coordination Hubs; facilitating and aligning with needs across priority economic sectors; and coordinating with other national-scale efforts related to AI readiness, workforce development, and technology diffusion. A successful National Lead will have strong national-level convening power and strategic oversight capabilities, supported by a strong team of partners.

Primary responsibilities include but are not limited to:

1. State/Territory-level Coordination Hub Support and Technical Assistance:

Providing direct support to Coordination Hubs through, for example, Hub convenings focused on knowledge sharing, delivering targeted technical assistance, and elevating and disseminating effective practices;

2. National-Level Knowledge Sharing and Visibility:

Maintaining national visibility and knowledge sharing by operating public-facing tools and channels — such as dashboards, repositories, and regular briefings — to provide a nationwide view of program activities, sector initiatives, and overall progress, ensuring transparency, informing stakeholders, complementing Coordination Hub and sector knowledge-sharing, and integrating with other national-scale efforts;

3. AI Deployment Network

Assisting state and local entities in applying AI to address local priorities through, for example, establishing and managing a nationally coordinated, locally embedded AI-Deployment Corps of credentialed experts to accelerate AI adoption, ensuring consistent, high-quality deployment assistance across the country while enabling states to tailor support to their local priorities and contexts;

4. Industry and Philanthropy Engagement

Mobilizing industry and philanthropic partners to contribute resources, expertise, and direct assistance, as well as internships, co-ops, and industry-sponsored projects; and

5. National Coordination Within Priority Sectors

Guiding national efforts to advance AI adoption in priority sectors — such as healthcare, financial services, advanced manufacturing, and agriculture — drawing on Coordination Hub priorities and emerging national needs.

More details about the National Lead will be made available in a separate funding call requesting proposals which will be issued as an Other Transaction Agreement Solutions Offering (OTASO). A link to the OTASO will be made available on the TechAccess: AI-Ready America program page when the OTASO is released.

Program Area 3: AI-Ready Catalyst Award Competitions

The AI-Ready Catalyst Award Competitions are designed to rapidly pilot and scale approaches that address high-priority national needs in AI readiness. These competitions provide deployment funding in targeted topics to enable the National Lead, NSF, and its partners to identify, test, and expand strategies that accelerate AI adoption and workforce development across a range of communities and sectors. Projects funded through these competitions may incorporate experiential learning models to accelerate skill development and AI adoption.

More details about these competitions will be made available in separate funding opportunity announcements. Links to these funding announcements will be added to the TechAccess: AI-Ready America program page as the opportunities are released.

III. Award Information

Up to 56 awards; one for every state, the District of Columbia, or territory in the U.S. Coordination Hubs will be selected over three rounds: 10 Coordination Hubs in round one, 20 in round two, and the remainder in round three. Each Coordination Hub Award will receive support of \$1M/year for three years, with the possibility for one additional year of support if the Coordination Hub can demonstrate a compelling need as it phases out or transitions to other sources of funding. Each Coordination Hub award will be made as a Standard Grant or Continuing Grant.

The program will additionally support a National Coordination Lead award announced through an Other Transaction Agreement Solutions Offering as well as AI-Ready Catalyst Awards, to be announced through Dear Colleague Letters or through the National Coordination Lead.

Estimated program budget, number of awards and average award size/duration are subject to the availability of funds.

IV. Eligibility Information

Who May Submit Proposals:

The categories of proposers eligible to submit proposals to the National Science Foundation are identified in the *NSF Proposal & Award Policies & Procedures Guide* (PAPPG), Chapter I.E. Unaffiliated individuals are not eligible to submit proposals in response to this solicitation.

Who May Serve as PI:

There are no restrictions or limits.

Limit on Number of Proposals per Organization: 1

Coordination Hubs are limited to one proposal per institution.

Limit on Number of Proposals per PI or co-PI:

There are no restrictions or limits.

V. Proposal Preparation and Submission Instructions

A. Proposal Preparation Instructions

Letters of Intent (*required*):

Letters of intent must be submitted by 5:00pm submitting organization's local time on the due date indicated elsewhere in this solicitation.

The Letters of Intent will not be used as a pre-approval mechanism for the submission of proposals and no feedback will be provided to submitters. The Letters of Intent will be used by NSF to assess requirements for proposal review. For more information on Letters of Intent, please review the NSF PAPPG. Note that no Supplementary Documents are allowed.

Letters of Intent MUST include the following:

- Title that begins with "[Full name of state, DC, or territory] Coordination Hub", followed by the title. The rest of the title of the proposal should describe the project in precise, informative language, without use of acronyms so that a technically literate reader can understand the project.
- In the Project PI and Other Senior Project Personnel sections, list the full names and institutional affiliations for the PI and all Co-PIs and Senior Personnel on the project, including all sub-awardees. The point of contact for NSF inquiries must be the PI, with the PI's e-mail address.
- In the Participating Organizations section, list all the institutions involved in the project including community partners.
- In the Synopsis section, provide a synopsis that describes the work in sufficient detail to permit an appropriate selection of potential reviewers (limit: one page).

Letter of Intent Preparation Instructions:

When submitting a Letter of Intent through Research.gov in response to this Program Solicitation please note the conditions outlined below:

- Submission by an Authorized Organizational Representative (AOR) is not required when submitting Letters of Intent.
- A Minimum of 0 and Maximum of 4 Other Senior Project Personnel are permitted
- A Minimum of 0 and Maximum of 20 Other Participating Organizations are permitted
- Submission of multiple Letters of Intent is not permitted

Full Proposal Preparation Instructions: Proposers may opt to submit proposals in response to this Program Solicitation via Research.gov or Grants.gov.

You must prepare your proposal according to [Chapter II.D.2 of the PAPPG](#), unless this solicitation specifies different instructions. Always use the version of the PAPPG in effect on your proposal's due date.

- For proposals submitted via Research.gov, [PAPPG](#) guidelines apply.
- For proposals submitted via Grants.gov, [NSF Grants.gov Application Guide](#) guidelines apply.

In determining which method to utilize in the electronic preparation and submission of the proposal, please note the following:

Collaborative Proposals. All collaborative proposals submitted as separate submissions from multiple organizations must be submitted via Research.gov. [PAPPG Chapter II.E.3](#) provides additional information on collaborative proposals.

Proposals are limited to 15 pages for the Project Description. Proposals that exceed the page limits will be returned without review. References do not count as part of the page limits.

Proposals must include Sections 1 – 5 using the specified section headers. Additional content may be included within these sections as appropriate. Failure to comply with the five section headers will be grounds for Return Without Review (RWR). For each section, items listed are provided as guidance for consideration and are not exhaustive.

Section 1 - Vision and Approach to Responsibilities

Describe your vision for advancing statewide AI readiness and how it aligns with program goals and the responsibilities noted in the Program Description.

Items to consider:

- How the proposed Coordination Hub will effectively execute the five areas of responsibility laid out in the Program Description. Coordination Hubs may propose additional responsibilities.
- Strategies for statewide coordination and scaling.
- Evidence of prior experience delivering similar statewide or multi-sector initiatives.
- Strategies for supporting small-scale local pilots through partnerships or future funding opportunities.

Section 2 - Organizational Background, Team Expertise, and Partnership Rationale

Describe the lead organization's profile, team expertise, and partnership rationale.

The lead organization should demonstrate statewide convening power, operational capacity, and experience managing multi-sector initiatives. Proposers may draw on partnerships to collectively bring the capabilities needed to implement the Coordination Hub's responsibilities. These include the ability to coordinate across education, workforce, industry, and government stakeholders; provide hands-on support for AI adoption; and develop and maintain a strategic plan for statewide AI readiness. AI expertise — covering both technical understanding and practical implementation — is essential but may be provided through partnerships rather than solely by the lead organization.

A proposer is encouraged to assemble partnerships that best fit their state's priorities around AI readiness and are encouraged to leverage the state's existing organizational structures around technology adoption and AI resources. Proposers should consider, for example, academic institutions (e.g. research universities, community and technical colleges) alongside organizations that support workforce development (e.g. America Job Centers, other state-level workforce development), technology adoption (e.g. State Cooperative Extension, regional innovation alliances, technology councils, Small Business Development Centers), and coordination (e.g. state and local government, agencies and offices). Proposers should describe how these partnerships will collectively advance program goals.

Items to consider:

- Key qualifications of team members and their roles in implementing the Coordination Hub.
- Why specific partners were selected and what unique contributions they bring.
- How the team will collaborate, including governance and decision-making structures. NSF encourages the use of at least one Advisory Board as part of the Coordination Hub's strategy.

- What gaps exist in the Coordination Hub's proposed partnerships and plans for filling those gaps.

Note: letters of collaboration are required from all partners to confirm commitment and should be submitted as Supplemental Material.

Section 3 - Current State of AI Planning and Coordination

Provide an overview of existing efforts in the state/territory and explain how the proposed Coordination Hub will build on these efforts to accelerate progress.

Items to consider:

- Key stakeholders and initiatives currently involved in AI readiness within the state/territory.
- What is working well and where gaps or unmet needs exist.
- How the Coordination Hub will help the state more rapidly and effectively achieve its AI-readiness goals.

Section 4 - Work Plan, Milestones, and Performance Metrics

Present a clear work plan for each area of responsibility described in the Vision and Approach to Responsibilities described in Section 1.

Items to consider:

- Major milestones and timelines for implementation.
- Performance metrics for tracking progress and feeding into national dashboards.
- How data will be collected and reported to support evidence-based scaling.

As you develop this section, consider that State/Territory Coordination Hubs will be required by NSF to submit a set of performance metrics by which they will track and report outcomes and assess the need for changes to focus and approach. These should include but are not limited to:

- Number of individuals trained (by category: educators, workforce, small business owners).
- Number of small businesses and government entities assisted and hours or dollars saved through AI adoption.
- Number of statewide convenings held and guidance facilitated for alignment.
- Contributions to national best-practice repositories and participation in sector-specific coordination activities.
- Number of individuals trained for the AI Deployment Corps and actively providing assistance.
- Number of organizations provided technical assistance.

The above constitute Measures of Success for the AI-Ready America initiative more generally as well.

Section 5 - Resource Mobilization and Leveraging Additional Support

Explain strategies for attracting additional resources to complement NSF funding and enable full implementation of the Coordination Hub's responsibilities.

Items to consider:

- Plans for securing additional financial or in-kind support from industry, philanthropy, state agencies, and/or other sources.
- How these resources will be integrated into the Coordination Hub's activities to expand reach, impact, and eventual self-sustainment.

Supplemental Materials

Proposals may include only those supplemental materials permitted by the NSF Proposal & Award Policies and Procedures Guide (PAPPG) and those explicitly required in this solicitation. For this program:

- **Letters of Collaboration** are required from all partners identified in the proposal and should follow the format described in the PAPPG.
- A **Data Management Plan** must be included, consistent with PAPPG requirements, as awards will involve data collection and reporting.
- A **Mentoring Plan** must be included if the proposal requests funding for postdoctoral researchers or graduate students.
- No letters of support or additional narrative materials are permitted.

National Coordination Lead

Proposal preparation instructions will be provided through a separate solicitation supporting an Other Transaction Award.

AI-Ready Catalyst Award Competitions

Proposal preparation instructions for each Catalyst Award Competition will be included in the NSF-approved funding opportunity announcement for the given competition.

B. Budgetary Information

Cost Sharing:

Inclusion of voluntary committed cost sharing is prohibited.

C. Research.gov/Grants.gov Requirements

You can submit proposals in response to this solicitation through Research.gov or Grants.gov, unless otherwise noted.

Information on how to prepare and submit proposals is available on the [Submitting Your Proposal](#) page on NSF.gov.

VI. NSF Proposal Processing and Review Procedures

Information on NSF's proposal processing and review procedures is available on the [Overview of the NSF Proposal and Award Process](#) page on NSF.gov.

A. Merit Review Principles and Criteria

All NSF proposals are evaluated through use of the two National Science Board-approved merit review criteria:

- **Intellectual Merit**, which encompasses the potential to advance knowledge.
- **Broader Impacts**, which encompass the potential to benefit society and contribute to the achievement of specific, desired societal outcomes.

Information on NSF's merit review principles and process can be found on the [How We Make Funding Decisions](#) page on NSF.gov.

Additional Solicitation Specific Review Criteria

To what extent is it evident that the proposed State/Territory Coordination Hub:

1. Presents a clear vision and approach for advancing statewide AI readiness in alignment with program goals, national AI-readiness priorities, and responsibilities of the Coordination Hub.
2. Has a lead organization and partners that demonstrate statewide/territory-wide convening and coordination capacity, along with the expertise needed to implement the responsibilities effectively.

3. Reflects an understanding of current state/territory efforts in AI and related areas and offers strategies to address gaps and accelerate progress.
4. Includes realistic milestones, measurable outcomes, and mechanisms for evidence-based implementation and scaling of efforts.
5. Outlines credible strategies for mobilizing additional resources to expand impact beyond NSF funding.

B. Review and Selection Process

Proposals submitted in response to this program solicitation will be reviewed by Ad hoc Review and/or Panel Review, Internal NSF Review, or Reverse Site Review.

Partners listed under Participating Directorates and Agencies may participate in the proposal review process.

After a proposal passes an initial compliance check, it will be reviewed by an NSF Program Officer. In most cases, three or more external experts will also review it (either as ad hoc reviewers, panelists or both).

Visit the [Overview of the NSF Proposal and Award Process](#) page for more information on the proposal review and selection process.

VII. Award Administration Information

A. Notification of the Award

Notification of an award is made to *the submitting organization* by an NSF Grants and Agreements Officer.

B. Award Conditions

Information on NSF award conditions can be found on the [Award Terms and Conditions](#) page on NSF.gov and [Chapter VII of the PAPPG](#).

Administrative and National Policy Requirements:

Information on administrative and national policy requirements can be found on the [National Policy Requirements for Recipients of NSF Awards](#) page on NSF.gov.

Special Award Conditions:

Coordination Hub Awardees should anticipate occasional engagement with other federal agencies participating in AI-Ready America to support coordination and alignment with national efforts.

Alignment and Collaboration between the Coordination Hubs and the National Lead

As a condition of award, State/Territory Coordination Hubs will be required to actively collaborate with the National Coordination Lead (National Lead) once established. This collaboration will encompass the areas of interaction described under the responsibilities of each entity in the Program Description — such as participation in Hub convenings, contributing to national dashboards and best-practice repositories, engaging in AI Deployment Network activities, and coordinating sector-specific initiatives. Collaboration will also include regular progress updates to the National Lead to support program monitoring.

The structure and frequency of interactions will be determined collaboratively by NSF and the National Lead, in consultation with the Coordination Hubs. The initial cohort of Coordination Hubs (round 1 awardees) will play a critical role in shaping these interactions. NSF is committed to ensuring these requirements provide clear value to awardees and do not impose undue burden; the National Lead will maintain an ongoing focus on streamlining engagement and maximizing benefit to participating Hubs.

C. Reporting Requirements

Unless your award notice says otherwise, NSF requires the principal investigator of every grant to submit annual project reports and a project outcomes report for the general public. For complete reporting requirements, see [Chapter VII of the PAPPG](#).

VIII. Agency Contacts

For questions related to the use of NSF systems contact:

- **Research.gov:** NSF IT Service Desk at rgov@nsf.gov or 1-800-381-1532. The Service Desk is open from 7 a.m. to 9 p.m. Eastern time, Monday through Friday (except for federal holidays).

For questions relating to Grants.gov contact:

- **Grants.gov:** The Grants.gov Contact Center at support@grants.gov or 1-800-518-4726. (Contact if the Authorized Organizational Representative (AOR) has not received a confirmation message from Grants.gov within 48 hours of submitting an application.)

IX. Other Information

For information on NSF directorates, programs and funding opportunities, go to [NSF.gov](https://www.nsf.gov).

About the National Science Foundation

The U.S. National Science Foundation is an independent federal agency created by the "National Science Foundation Act of 1950." More information about NSF can be found on [NSF.gov](https://www.nsf.gov).

- | | |
|--|--|
| • Location: | Randolph Building, 401 Dulany Street, Alexandria, VA 22314 |
| • General Information | (703) 292-5111 |
| • TDD (for the hearing-impaired): | (703) 292-5090 |

Privacy Act And Public Burden Statements

The information requested on proposal forms and project reports is solicited under the authority of the "National Science Foundation Act of 1950," as amended. More information can be found on the [Privacy Act and Public Burden Statements](#) page on NSF.gov.

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